

Stave churches

Scandinavia remained outside the Christian sphere until about the middle of the 11th century, when Anglo-Saxon missionaries returned with Viking raiders from England and preached Christianity. The missionaries also brought knowledge of Christian church architecture with them, and soon began to put up small, simple churches based on a fusion of English Christian churches and native styles. These stave churches were usually wooden and windowless, the name deriving from the load-bearing posts in the timber framing, which were called *stafr* in Old Norse. Although they were once common across all of northern Europe, most surviving examples are in Norway, such as the church at Urnes, dating from c.1125 to 1140 (although it is possible that a previous Christian church was on the site). Bringing together elements of Celtic and Viking art and Romanesque architecture, the small, dark building (opposite) has cylindrical columns and semicircular arches with carvings and sculpture on many internal wooden panels, predominantly featuring interlaced Celtic-style patterns.

